However, the largest collection of foreign fighters within the Taliban's ranks came from Pakistan, with estimates ranging as high as 7,000 by 2001.[16] A sizeable number came from Deobandi madaris in Pakistan, several of which had graduated the Taliban movement's leaders. Some madaris cancelled classes for extended periods of time and sent their entire student body into combat alongside the Taliban.[17] Some of these students were also connected to various Deobandi militant groups or the JUI, the Deobandi political party to which many of these militants groups traced their roots. A breakdown of 109 Pakistani prisoners captured fighting with the Taliban by the Northern Alliance revealed that of those held between October 1999 and March 2000, 51 were from the Harkat-ul-Mujahideen and 49 were from the JUI. Only 33 of 109 identified were Pashtun, indicating that support extended beyond ethnic solidarity.[18]

Fighting the Northern Alliance was a right of passage for many of the militants graduating from training camps in Taliban-controlled territory and doing so was compulsory for those belonging to Pakistan's Deobandi outfits according to several Pakistani interlocutors. The ISI moved some training facilities for militants fighting in the Kashmir jihad to Afghanistan after the Taliban took power, and as mentioned a number of foreign jihadi groups established camps there as well. Al-Qaeda initially operated some camps while supporting others, which enabled bin Laden to build his base and cherry-pick the small number of recruits officially asked to join his organization.[19] For example, the ISI persuaded the Taliban to give al-Qaeda control of the al-Badr camps, which it earlier had handed over to Harkat-ul-Ansar [the group formed when Harkat-ul-Mujahideen and HuJI merged]. HuA militants as well as those from the sectarian Lashkar-e-Jhangvi continued to train there.[20] Some of the militants killed when the US launched cruise missile strikes against al-Badr in 1998 following al-Qaeda's attack against two US embassies in East Africa belonged to Harkat-ul-Ansar, which by this time was again calling itself Harkat-ul-Mujahideen.[21]

Bin Laden's relationship with Maulana Fazl-ur Rehman Khalil, who led HuM, stretched back to the war against the Soviets.[22] Despite their differing Islamic schools of thought, HuM became notoriously close with al-Qaeda because of their shared training experience.[23] After being displaced by Lashkar as the premier Pakistani proxy in Indian-administered